PORTLAND PUBLIC SCHOOLS
BOARD OF EDUCATION MEMORANDUM

To: Portland Public Schools Board of Education

From: Dr. Kimberlee Armstrong, Superintendent and Dr. Kelli Charles, Interim Chief Accountability and Equity Officer

Date: November 4, 2026

Subject: Focal Student Outcomes and Educational Equity: Understanding Student Achievement, Opportunity, and District Accountability

Purpose

The purpose of this memorandum is to provide the Board of Education with an overview of the November 4, 2026, presentation, *Focal Student Outcomes and Educational Equity*. The presentation fulfills the district's Oregon Statewide Assessment System (OSAS) reporting responsibility while focusing intentionally on the educational experiences and academic outcomes of four focal student populations: Black students, Native American students, multilingual learners, and students with disabilities.

The presentation is intended to deepen the Board's understanding of the historical and educational contexts that have shaped opportunities for these students; examine current academic performance across Portland Public Schools (PPS); highlight district efforts to support student success; and identify areas requiring continued attention and improvement. I will be joined by district leaders representing each focal student population, who will share student strengths, successes, challenges, and the district's ongoing responses.

The Board received the 2025 Oregon Statewide Assessment System (OSAS) Results Memorandum in October 2026. Building upon this assessment reporting, the November 4 presentation moves beyond proficiency results to examine educational opportunity, instructional effectiveness, and the district's collective responsibility for improving student outcomes.

The central question guiding this presentation is:

To what extent are we delivering on the promise of public education for every student, and what must we do differently to ensure that all students experience meaningful academic success?

Background and Context

Public education has not historically provided equitable access, experiences, or opportunities to all students. Race, language, disability, and identity have shaped students' access to educational institutions, rigorous instruction, appropriate supports, and pathways to future opportunity. For Black students, the history of American education includes legal exclusion, segregation, and persistent disparities in educational opportunity. Native American students and communities have experienced educational policies intended to suppress Indigenous languages, cultures, and identities. Multilingual learners have encountered educational approaches that have not always recognized linguistic diversity as an asset, while students with disabilities have historically faced exclusion from general education and unequal access to rigorous academic instruction.

These histories are distinct and should not be treated as interchangeable. However, they provide essential context for understanding why educational equity requires intentional examination of institutional practices, access to opportunity, and student outcomes. PPS recognizes that historically underserved describes the experiences students have had within educational systems, not their abilities, potential, or aspirations. Our focal student populations bring significant cultural, linguistic, intellectual, and community strengths to our schools. This presentation approaches educational equity through both an asset-based understanding of students and a clear expectation of institutional accountability. The responsibility of the district is to create and sustain educational conditions in which every student can achieve.

Overview of Student Achievement

The presentation examines 2025–26 OSAS results in English language arts and mathematics, with attention to districtwide proficiency, selected grade-level benchmarks, statewide comparisons, and patterns over time. The findings reveal areas of progress, significant differences among student populations, and persistent challenges requiring focused instructional attention.

Black Students

In 2025–26, 19.7% of Black students in PPS in Grades 3–8 met the state proficiency standard in English language arts, compared with 26.3% of Black students statewide. In mathematics, 13.2% of Black students in PPS met proficiency, compared with 17.8% statewide. These results indicate that PPS trails the statewide performance of Black students in both subjects. The presentation also examines grade-level benchmarks, including third-grade literacy and mathematics performance, to better understand the consistency of academic progress. The findings reinforce the need to examine access to rigorous grade-level instruction, the effectiveness of academic interventions, and the consistency of educational experiences for Black students across schools and regions.

Native American Students

In 2025–26, 22.0% of Native American students in PPS in Grades 3–8 met proficiency in English language arts, compared with 26.3% statewide. In mathematics, 20.6% of Native American students in PPS met proficiency, exceeding the statewide rate of 17.6%. The mathematics results represent an area of relative strength that warrants further examination. At the same time, proficiency in both subjects demonstrates the need for continued improvement.

Because Native American student populations are relatively small in some grades and regions, proficiency percentages can fluctuate significantly from year to year. Interpretation must therefore consider the number of students tested, suppressed data, and multiyear patterns. The district's response must continue to emphasize rigorous academic instruction alongside culturally sustaining practices, meaningful family and Tribal community engagement, and recognition of Native American students' identities, languages, and histories.

Multilingual Learners

In 2025–26, 6.2% of PPS students identified as current English learners in Grades 3–8 met proficiency standards in English language arts, and 8.5% met proficiency standards in mathematics. These results reflect students currently receiving English language development services and should not be interpreted as representative of all multilingual students, including former English learners who have attained English proficiency. For context, statewide proficiency rates for current English learners were 6.1% in English language arts and 6.1% in mathematics. However, the statewide results include Grades 3–8 and 11,

while the PPS results reflect Grades 3–8 only. Because the grade spans differ, these figures should not be interpreted as directly equivalent comparisons.

The results underscore the importance of strengthening the connection between language development and academic achievement. English language development and rigorous academic instruction must occur together. Students should have meaningful opportunities to engage with grade-level content while receiving explicit language instruction and appropriate scaffolds. The district's ongoing work includes strengthening integrated English language development, collaborative instructional practices, and access to rigorous core instruction. Continued examination of English language development services, assessment practices, and targeted academic supports will be essential to accelerating student learning and achievement.

Students with Disabilities

In 2025–26, 34.0% of PPS students receiving special education services in Grades 3–8 met proficiency in English language arts, compared with 18.8% of students with disabilities statewide. In mathematics, 31.6% met proficiency, compared with 15.9% statewide. These results indicate substantially higher proficiency rates for PPS students with disabilities than the corresponding statewide student population. While these comparisons are encouraging, most PPS students receiving special education services are not yet meeting state proficiency standards.

Continued improvement requires attention to meaningful access to grade-level instruction, the effectiveness of specially designed instruction, individualized supports, and the alignment of services with measurable academic progress.

District Response: Successes, Challenges, and Priorities

Following the review of achievement data, district leaders will provide focused presentations addressing each of the four focal student populations. These presentations will highlight the distinct histories and strengths of students, the successes and challenges observed in their educational experiences, and the district's current work to strengthen academic achievement and access.

The presentations will address:

- **Black students:** Educational experiences, academic outcomes, and efforts to strengthen culturally responsive instruction, student belonging, and achievement.
- **Native American students:** Academic opportunities, cultural affirmation, engagement with Native families and communities, and culturally sustaining educational practices.
- **Multilingual learners:** English language development, access to grade-level academic instruction, and coordinated language and instructional supports.
- **Students with disabilities:** Inclusive educational opportunities, specially designed instruction, meaningful access to grade-level content, and improved student outcomes.

While the needs and experiences of these student populations are distinct, the district's collective responsibility is consistent: students must experience rigorous instruction, appropriate supports, high expectations, and learning environments that recognize and build upon their strengths.

From Investment to Instructional Impact

The presentation concludes by examining the relationship between district investments, instructional implementation, and student achievement. PPS has made investments in high-quality instructional materials, professional learning, assessment systems, and student supports. These investments establish important foundations for improving academic outcomes. However, the presence of instructional materials, professional development opportunities, or intervention systems does not independently demonstrate that students are experiencing improved learning. The district must increasingly examine how effectively these investments translate into classroom practice and measurable academic progress.

This requires attention to four interconnected priorities:

1. **Consistent access to high-quality, grade-level instruction.** Students must experience rigorous, evidence-based instruction supported by adopted instructional materials and effective teaching practices.
2. **Timely and effective academic supports.** Students requiring additional instruction or intervention must receive responsive supports without unnecessary removal from grade-level learning opportunities.

3. **Instruction responsive to student strengths and needs.** Educational practices must account for linguistic, cultural, disability-related, and individualized learning needs while maintaining high expectations.
4. **Evidence-based monitoring and continuous improvement.** Student learning evidence must inform instructional adjustments, professional learning, resource allocation, and decisions about the effectiveness of district initiatives.

The district's responsibility extends beyond documenting what has been implemented. It includes determining whether implementation is effective, whether students are benefiting, and what changes are necessary when intended results are not achieved.

Implications for District Accountability and Continuous Improvement

The findings presented on November 4 reinforce the importance of connecting educational equity to the district's ongoing improvement and accountability efforts. The Office of Accountability, Equity, and Continuous Improvement will continue working across departments to strengthen the use of student outcome data, support the examination of instructional conditions, and promote greater coherence between district priorities, investments, and results.

Particular attention must be given to identifying persistent patterns of underperformance, examining variation across schools and regions, and ensuring that improvement efforts are responsive to the experiences of focal student populations. The district must also recognize that student achievement cannot be understood through assessment results alone. Attendance, access to rigorous coursework, school climate, belonging, effective instructional supports, and other educational conditions contribute to students' opportunities to learn and succeed.

A meaningful approach to accountability requires the district to examine both student outcomes and the conditions that influence those outcomes. This work is central to ensuring that educational equity is reflected not only in district commitments, but also in the educational experiences and academic progress of students.

Looking Ahead

The November 4 presentation is intended to support continued Board and district discussion about the relationship between educational opportunity, student achievement, and

institutional responsibility. The findings underscore the need for sustained attention to the academic experiences of historically underserved students, a deeper understanding of variation across the district, and a disciplined approach to evaluating the effectiveness of instructional practices and investments.

The district's goal is not simply to improve proficiency percentages. It is to ensure that students leave Portland Public Schools prepared to pursue postsecondary education, meaningful careers, economic opportunity, and futures of their own choosing. Our responsibility is to create educational conditions that make those opportunities possible for every student.

Board Consideration

This presentation is provided for the Board's information, discussion, and continued oversight of district efforts to improve student outcomes and advance educational equity.

No Board action is requested at this time.

Appendices and Supporting Materials

- **Appendix A:** Focal Student Outcomes and Educational Equity Presentation, November